Anirudhya's source had refused to share anything more, fearing a story in the press would refresh the debate about whether withdrawing Rajiv Gandhi's SPG cover when he was the leader of the Opposition had been a legitimate move. Politics aside, the truth had to be reported. Anirudhya tried for an audience with the person behind the sensitive report, B. Raman, but in vain.

Kondath Mohandas, former director general (intelligence) of the Tamil Nadu Police, was feeling out of the limelight. Raman had worked under him at some point in the state intelligence department. He agreed to convince Raman to speak to *India Today*. However, he laid a condition for Anirudhya—the meeting had to be held at his apartment. Anirudhya agreed. The Madras bureau of the R&AW had earlier aired similar concerns about the LTTE's attitude towards Rajiv Gandhi, that the Sri Lankan Tamils were the biggest threat to him. Then why did the R&AW chief G.S. Bajpai deny the LTTE's hand in the assassination?

Bajpai's denial was an open secret by then. The fact that this had drawn flak from the IB, the CBI, the Tamil Nadu Police and other security agencies was no secret either. Raman claimed later that even shortly after the assassination of Rajiv Gandhi, at a meeting of concerned officers, he was asked for his views about who might have killed Rajiv Gandhi. Raman's instant reply was the LTTE. But his view was dismissed, Raman said. The problem was that the security agencies in Delhi and the security experts from the JIC had got it into their heads that the Tamil Tigers wouldn't strike at Rajiv Gandhi since his Sri Lankan policies and his mother's had actually helped the Sri Lankan Tamil struggle more than anything done by any other Indian political leader. New Delhi never looked deep into the making of Velupillai Prabhakaran, and therefore didn't anticipate what he was capable of.

A study of what had shaped Prabhakaran was therefore becoming necessary. To his followers, Velupillai Prabhakaran was a revolutionary fighting for the liberation of the Tamils in Sri Lanka. To his critics he was a narcissist with an obsession for power who had no regard for human life. Someone who had reportedly killed the mayor of Jaffna at the age of